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CHAOS REIGNS AT THIRUVANMIYUR BUS TERMINUS

Commuters request MTC to make announcements that the buses from East Coast Road will stop at South Avenue Road. **P2**



WOMEN RECEIVE'GOLDEN WINGS'

An initiative by Chennai-based Care Earth Trust is training local women in Vedanthangal and Unamancheri to identify birds, lead nature walks and earn a livelihood while spreading biodiversity awareness. **P4**

An 'organic' gift to Perungudi



With a fresh initiative, Chennai Organic Market establishes its third market in Chennai; the market will be open today at Vallalar Sanmargam Arangam on OMR

The Chennai Organic Market (COM) aimed at bringing safe food for customers and ensuring fair prices for farmers for their produce, is being launched on October 11 in Perungudi. This is COM's third such market, the other two being at Shenoy Nagar and Velachery.

The market, which will start by 10 a.m., will have leafy greens, vegetables and fruits, sweets and savouries made with organic ingredients, organic grocery, ready-to-cook items and beverages. Organic clothes and herbal plants too would be on sale at the market that would come to a close by 5 p.m.

Workshops, storytelling and games too have been planned for the day.

An entry fee of ₹100 would be charged for a session on Marundilla Maruthuvam that would be held from 11 a.m. to 1 p.m. A Tirukkural competition in which participants would be asked to give the meaning of the couplets is also planned.

According to Ananthoo of the Safe Food Alliance, the aim of the Organic Farmers Market is to create a space where safe, wholesome food reaches consumers at fair prices while farmers receive a fair value for their produce.

Customers are encouraged to bring their own bags for purchases and containers for organic cold pressed oil and other tasty treats. For more details, call 8122264595/ 7094661985.

The market is happening at Vallalar Sanmargam Arangam on Rajiv Gandhi Salai (OMR) in Perungudi, near the Selva Vinayagar Temple, opposite the Kun Skoda Car showroom.

A mother and son's expedition with books



The Reading Elf in Thoraipakkam gets children to fall in love with reading

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

When Shweta Subbiah and her son, Adhruth, returned from London in 2018, there was something they badly missed in the city: a cosy little space where they could discover their own books and then buy the book.

They visited several bookstores and loved the experience, but found themselves wishing for something more – a space where children could linger for hours, browse freely, curl up with a book and develop a genuine love for reading.

And so, The Reading Elf was born. A mother's dream of creating a magical reading space for children has grown into The Reading Elf, an independent



bookstore in Thoraipakkam.

Founded by Shweta, with Adhruth (*in picture*) as its inspiration, the bookstore carries a personal story. Shweta affectionately calls her son her "little elf" – her cheerful companion and helper. Three years before opening the physical store, she had started an Instagram page dedicated to reviewing and recommending children's books. The name The Reading Elf seemed a natural fit: it reflected the way she saw her own little elf and the world of stories they were creating together, says a note.

The Reading Elf stocks books for everyone from babies to young teens, including picture books, early readers, chapter books, graphic novels and reference titles. Shweta personally curates the collection, with particular attention to age-appropriateness, quality and books that offer children something meaningful beyond entertainment.

"We encourage children to select their own book," says Shweta. "Your child is not going to like the same book that you did. Parents tend to push the child towards what they think the child should read, which I don't confirm to," says Shweta, who has grown up visiting Landmark bookstore.

Children visiting the store can interact with fellow young readers. Like there's nine-year-old Adhruth, the "chief book explorer", sharing his favourites, and 15-year-old Sanu, who offers her recommendation.

The logo was conceived by Adhruth and brought to life by a designer, it features a little elf sitting inside a mushroom house, completely absorbed in a book.

The Reading Elf hosts storytelling sessions, book clubs, workshops and other experiences designed to help children engage with books. Shweta says they will soon be starting a reading space on the floor above the book store. "Read a little before you go and that's why our space is special," she adds.

The Reading Elf is at Marigold, Old No. 3/58, New No. 3/76, Kumaran Kudil Main Road, Thoraipakkam. Phone: 95000 56482 | Website: www.thereadingelf.in/ Instagram: @the_reading_elf



Commuters at Thiruvanmiyur terminus on East Coast Road; and the stop on South Avenue Road. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Chaos reigns at

Thiruvanmiyur bus terminus

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

There is enough confusion for new commuters while waiting at Thiruvanmiyur bus terminus on East Coast Road.

Regular commuters have requested Metropolitan Transport Corporation to inform people that the buses from East Coast Road and those on South Avenue Road will stop at the haltover on Avenue Road. This must be done by placing display boards and making announcements.

S. Shiva, a daily commuter, says, "Newcomers think that this is the terminus and buses would start from here. After dropping commuters, along the old terminus, bus drivers either halt on ECR, along the Thiruvanmiyur market. At times, buses proceed towards Avenue Road with and without display boards. Commuters do not know which buses are going and where. At times, commuters have to run after the buses. The lane on ECR where a section of MTC buses, starting from the terminal, currently stops is a market road, and bus drivers sometimes park on South Avenue Road to avoid congestion.

The buses also start from Avenue Road. It is better to wait at South Avenue Road haltover, says S. Srinath.

Commuters end up missing the buses. There are no display boards or announcements about this. Commuters learn this from fellow commuters. Besides, MTC should provide a signboard with directions to the haltover. Commuters can walk through Mangala Eri Road to the haltover but end up taking a detour through ECR and Kamarajar Nagar 22nd Street, Srinath adds.

FORRRA urges NPCI to exempt RWA maintenance collections

The Federation of Radial Road Residents Associations (FORRRA) has urged the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) to reconsider the proposed 0.4% UPI Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on residential community / RWA maintenance collections above ₹2,000, proposed to take effect from October 15 this year.

RWAs and Apartment Owners Associations operate on a non-profit, cost-recovery basis. The maintenance contributions collected from residents are used solely for essential common services such as security, water, electricity, lifts, sewage treatment, housekeeping and other community infrastructure.

FORRRA has pointed out that while direct payments towards certain essential utilities qualify for a flat ₹5 MDR, collecting the same funds through a registered RWA could attract a 0.4% charge. This creates an unnecessary additional burden on residents.

For example, a ₹25,000 maintenance payment would attract ₹100 MDR, despite the RWA neither selling a product nor earning a commercial profit from the transaction.

FORRRA has requested NPCI to create a separate category for registered RWAs / Apartment Owners Associations and extend the applicable ₹5 flat MDR – or a suitable zero/nominal MDR – to genuine non-profit maintenance collections, said a release.

The federation believes that digital payments should be encouraged, not penalised, particularly when they are being used by residents to transparently fund essential community services.

FORRRA has urged NPCI and the authorities concerned to consider this request before the proposed October 15, 2026 , implementation.

A Sunday of cars, clues and community



MRC Nagar came alive over the weekend with a unique neighbourhood car rally that brought families together for a Sunday of driving, quizzing and treasure hunting.

Organised with the support of the MRC Nagar Residents Association and Ceebros 174, the rally transformed the neighbourhood into an interactive trail, with participating families navigating familiar streets, solving clues and discovering lesser-known facets of MRC Nagar.

Conceived, directed and managed by Shoba Ravishankar, the event featured a specially curated quiz on the neighbourhood, covering its history, landmarks and interesting local trivia. The quiz drew enthusiastic participation, with residents keen on testing their knowledge of their own neighbourhood, said a press release.

Adding to the experience was a lunch and high tea sponsored by Broken Bridge Café by Radio Room, along with ice creams from Arun Icecreams and takeaway desserts from Muffinbox.

Lanson Toyota and Zimson Watches were the principal sponsors of the event, while Toyota Vellfire, Toyota Camry and Toyota Hilux added an automotive highlight to the day's proceedings, added the release.

Club makes a donation towards animal welfare

Round Table and Ladies Circle India, Area 2, in association with Besant Memorial Animal Dispensary, organised an immunisation and sterilisation drive to promote responsible pet care and animal welfare. As part of this initiative, a donation of ₹2 lakh was made to support the dispensary's efforts in immunisation, sterilisation, treatment, and care for wounded and abandoned pets, said a press release.

The occasion was graced by sports presenter and anchor Bhavna Balakrishnan. A lively question-and-answer session was conducted along with Bhavna Balakrishnan, Area Chairman Tr. Sanjieev Vir TH, Area Chairperson Cr. Sathwika Ravishankar, and fellow tablers and circlers.

Bhavna Balakrishnan shared an important message encouraging people to adopt pets and show greater empathy towards the pet community.

Workshop on natural fibres held

A one-day demonstration cum workshop on new age sustainable fibres like banana fibre was held recently at the Anakaputhur Natural Fibre Centre.

Students of the Department of Textile Design, NIFT Chennai took part in the workshop that focussed on development of products like baskets, tea coasters and table mats using banana fibre.

Mahesh Krishnamoorthy, OSD, Governor of Tamil Nadu, who was the chief guest at the programme, said that it was good to see students of design wanting to learn about natural fibres. He said more natural fibres should be used to make clothes so that farmers will also benefit from the same.

Weaver C. Sekar, founder and trainer, Ananafit, said Tamil Nadu stood second in the country when it came to extraction of naturally occurring fibres.

He pioneered the use of around 25 natural plant fiber including banana, aloe vera, bamboo, pineapple, hemp, gongura, and jute to produce eco-friendly garments, yardage, and herbal-infused saris.

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Women receive ‘Golden Wings’

An initiative by Chennai-based Care Earth Trust is training local women in Vedanthangal and Unamancheri to identify birds, lead nature walks and earn a livelihood while spreading biodiversity awareness

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Until recently, for some of the women living around Vedanthangal, the birds they saw every day were simply part of the landscape. Today, they are part of their life, even the sounds of these avians being familiar to these women’s now-trained ears. That transformation was engineered by a nature-guide training programme from Chennai-based Care Earth Trust.

With the two-fold objective of increasing biodiversity awareness and providing livelihood opportunities, the programme began with women and young people from around Vedanthangal, training them in bird identification, wetland ecology, identification of trees butterflies, and communication skills. After months of classroom lessons and practical sessions, a group of eight trained participants have come together as ‘Golden Wings’ and are now conducting guided walks at Vedanthangal.

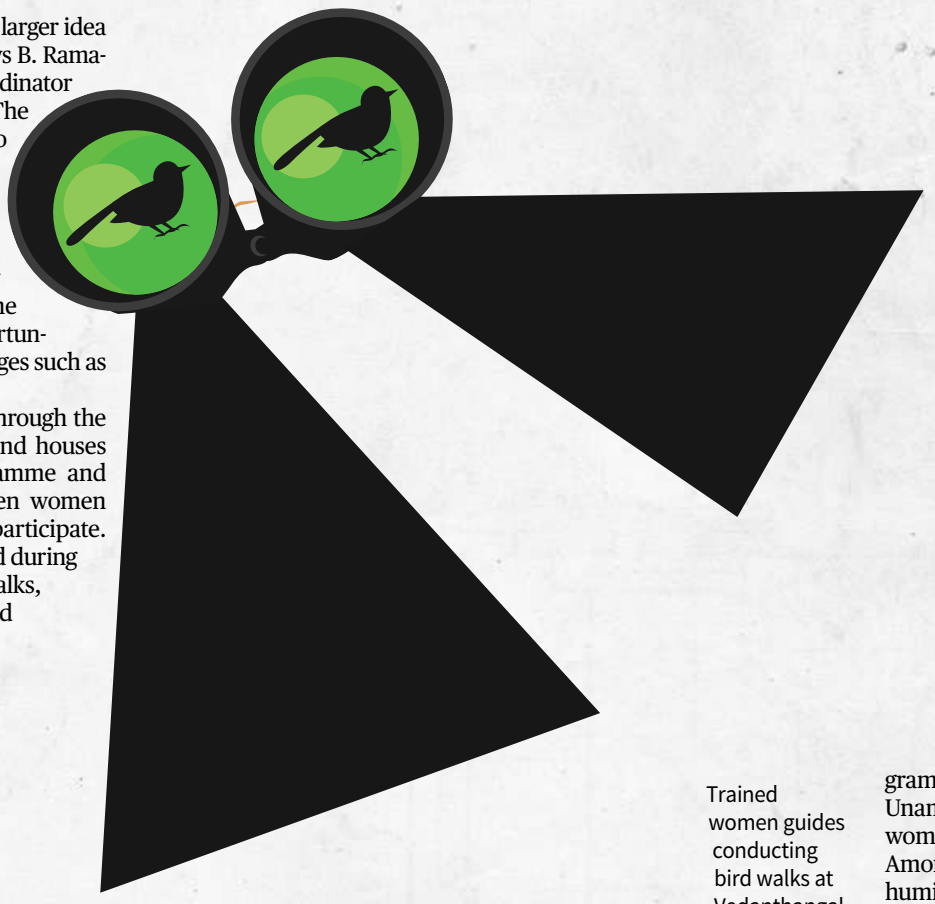
Vedanthangal resident S. Kalaiselvi Srinivasan, now a Golden Wings guide, says the work has given her an income opportunity as well as improved her communication skills.

For Subathirai D, however, the journey began with skepticism from those around her. When she first started attending the training, women in her neighbourhood questioned why she was spending her time on it. To them, learning about birds and nature seemed unnecessary, especially when she could be spending that time on household responsibilities or other work. But that perception began to change when Subathirai returned from the training and started earning through nature walks.

This is precisely the larger idea behind the project, says B. Ramamoorthy, Project Coordinator at Care Earth Trust. The organisation wanted to address two issues at once: the limited awareness among local communities about the biodiversity around them and the lack of livelihood opportunities for women in villages such as Vedanthangal.

The team worked through the panchayat, went around houses to explain the programme and spoke to families when women were hesitant to participate. Childcare was arranged during training and nature walks, food was provided, and the women themselves suggested Sundays as the most convenient day for classes.

The initial training involved classroom sessions using colour printouts and presentations to teach the participants about different birds, trees and butterflies. They then moved to practical walks, where they learnt to identify birds through their appearance and calls and understand local and native trees and their uses. They were also taken on a week-long exposure visit to Thattekad in Kerala to learn about forest biodiversity and migratory birds. The training did not stop with bird identification. The women were taught spoken English, people management and social-media skills.



Trained women guides conducting bird walks at Vedanthangal.

For Anjana Venkatesan, Programme Manager - Policy Research at Care Earth Trust, the project is about creating a connection between local women and the ecotourism circuit while drawing attention to the biodiversity outside Chennai. “Connecting them to the local kind of ecotourism circuit is a win-win for both of us,” she said. She also wants to challenge the perception that people have to travel to the Western Ghats to experience rich bird diversity. “Right in the outskirts of Chennai, you have these pockets with our existing forests and existing wetlands,” she said, adding that some of these areas record around 70 bird species during the migratory season.

The next phase of the programme is now taking shape in Unamancheri, Vandalur, where women are undergoing training. Among them is 29-year-old Madhumitha S., a B.Sc graduate who works in medical coding. Originally from Medavakkam, she moved to Unamancheri after marriage and has been attending the Sunday classes for around two months.

For Madhumitha, the training has meant discovering a side of the place she now calls home. Before joining the programme, she was familiar mainly with common birds. The classes introduced her to a much wider range of birds, trees, butterflies and other species.

Madhumitha is now learning how to handle tourists, engage them and conduct nature walks. She plans to continue her medical-coding job during the week and take up nature walks on weekends after completing her training.

Challani Jewellery exhibition open today at Taj Connemara

Challani Jewellery Mart's Challani's Jewelverse –Season 1, a grand showcase of exquisite jewellery, commenced on October 9 at Taj Connemara, under the leadership of Jayanthilal Challani, founder and chairman of Challani Jewellery Mart.

The exhibition was inaugurated by Adityaram, founder and chairman of the Adityaram Group who formally opened the event by cutting the ribbon and lighting the traditional ceremonial lamp.



According to a press release, the exhibition brings together an extensive collection of fine jewellery, featuring gold, diamonds, Polki, rose-cut diamonds and coloured gemstones under one roof. Combining traditional craftsmanship with contemporary designs, the showcase offers visitors an opportunity to explore a diverse range of distinctive jewellery collections.

Speaking to the media after the inauguration, Adityaram expressed his appreciation for the collection on display. "I have visited several jewellery exhibitions, but the variety of collections showcased here is truly remarkable. What stands out is the range of designs available not only for women but also for men, with distinctive pieces that are visually appealing," he said.

Jayanthilal Challani said although Challani Jewellery Mart has several branches, our objective is to bring different categories of jewellery together in one place, offering customers a comprehensive shopping experience. This exhibition features an exclusive selection of gold, diamond, Polki, rose-cut and coloured gemstone jewellery.

The inaugural event witnessed the participation of several prominent personalities, including Thangamalar Jagannath and Dr. Vimala Rani Britto, along with other distinguished guests and jewellery enthusiasts. Visitors were seen exploring the collections with considerable interest.

Challani's Jewelverse - Season 1 is being held from October 9 to 11 (between 10:00 a.m. and 9:00 p.m.)

Venue: Taj Connemara, Binny Road, Near Spencer Plaza

Skincare brand embarks on expansion in Asia



International premium beauty brand Miss Universe Skincare & Spa is expanding its global presence in Asia with the appointment of Hemamalini Rajinikanth of BM Healthcare Group as Regional Director - Miss Universe Skincare Asia.

According to a press release, the appointment was announced in Chennai by Olivia Quido, CEO, Miss Universe Skincare & Spa and Vice President - Global Operations, Miss Universe, alongside Dr. Hemamalini Rajinikanth and Dr. Rajinikanth, Plastic Surgeon.

The Asian expansion follows the signing of an MOU in Los Angeles on August 26, 2026, establishing the foundation for the brand's regional development.

BM Elite International Clinic, Velachery, Chennai, will serve as the Asia Headquarters, supporting brand development, partnerships, franchise opportunities and market expansion.

The initiative will bring together premium Miss Universe Skincare products and professional MedSpa services under one international beauty platform, adds the press release.

The initial markets identified for expansion include India, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore, Indonesia, the Philippines and Vietnam.

Olivia Quido said the Asian expansion marks an important chapter in the brand's journey to build a globally recognised beauty platform combining premium skincare with professional MedSpa experiences.

Dr. Hemamalini Rajinikanth said the goal is to establish Miss Universe Skincare & Spa as a distinctive premium beauty destination in Asia, while maintaining the brand's international identity and standards, adds the press release.

Charging station in Poonamallee

Zappang Charging Stations has opened an electric vehicle (EV) charging station at Motel Highway in Poonamallee.

The station features a 60 kW DC fast-charging facility, designed to provide convenient charging for EV users. Focused on clean energy and sustainable transportation, Zappang aims to make EV charging more accessible for motorists. The facility promotes a greener driving experience and encourages the transition towards environmentally friendly mobility solutions.

For location details and inquiries, contact 95666 83952.

Property expo in Pallavaram, Urapakkam

Today is the final day of ARK Eventz Property Expo 2026. The event is being held at Arul Murugan Towers, 200 Feet Radial Road, Old Pallavaram, and at Swapna Thirumana Mandapam, GST Road, Urapakkam; 10 a.m. to 7 p.m.

At the expo, prospective buyers can explore a wide range of property options, including apartments, villas, plots, and investment opportunities. Buyers can meet builders and developers, compare properties, and discover attractive options, said a release.

For registration and details, visit www.arkeventz.com or call 94444 56087.

Velammal Nexus felicitates Vithya Ramraj, Nehpal Singh



Velammal Nexus felicitated athlete Vithya Ramraj, who bagged three medals at the Asian Games, and her coach, Nehpal Singh. The felicitation ceremony was hosted by Velammal Vidyalaya in Avadi.

Vithya Ramraj, her mother Meena, and Nephal Singh were welcomed with a beautifully decorated chariot procession, flower garlands, and traditional ceremonial honours, creating an atmosphere of pride and celebration across the campus. As a mark of appreciation, Velammal Nexus presented a car each to Vithya Ramraj and Nephal Singh, said a release.

M.V. M. Velmohan, correspondent, Velammal Nexus, took part. Vithya's journey from rigorous training to winning medals at the Asian Games inspires thousands of young students aspiring to excel in sports, added the release.

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CM launches 'Dream Olympics'



Ishari K. Ganesh, president, Tamil Nadu Olympic Association, and founder-chancellor, Vels University, welcomed C. Joseph Vijay, Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, at The Leela Palace recently.

The CM launched the 'Dream Olympics' initiative and felicitated Tamil Nadu's Asian Games and chess olympiad medal winners at the event organised by Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT).

Aadhav Arjuna, State Minister for Sports Development, and prominent sportspersons were among those who took part in the event.

Pallavakkam resident's book release today

Ram Sundaresan, a Chennai-based executive and leadership coach, will launch his maiden book, *Rise from Success to Significance*, on October 11, 4 p.m. at The Learning Community at Quest, Rukmani Road Extension, Kalakshetra Colony in Besant Nagar.

Sundaresan, an International Coaching Federation (ICF) certified professional, through his book *Rise from Success to Significance*, shares his personal coaching journey, practical insights and experiences from working with leaders in the corporate finance sector, offering readers a closer look at how coaching can support personal and professional growth.

Navaratri music series till October 20

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan is conducting Navaratri music series under Saroja Parasaran Memorial Endowment from October 11 to October 20 at Bhavan's Main Hall in Mylapore. Two concerts are scheduled every day at 5 p.m. and at 6.30 p.m.

The programme schedule:

October 11; 4.30 p.m: Raghav Manian (Vocal/Instrumental); 6.30 p.m. Anahitha and Smt.Apoorva (Vocal)

October 12; 5 p.m. Aishwarya & Soundarya (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Sri Sruthi Sagar (Flute)

October 13; 5 p.m. Abhilash Venkitachalam (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Chinmaya Siste rs (Vocal)

October 14; 5 p.m. Vivek Moozhikulam (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Mambalam Sisters (Vocal)

October 15; 5 p.m. Lalitha Mohan (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Nisha Rajagopal (Vocal)

October 16; 5p.m. Chaitraa Sairam (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. J.B.Keerthana (Vocal)

October 17; 5 p.m. Mohan Santhanam (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Sankari Krishnan (Vocal)

October 18; Dwaraka Colony Bhajan Mandali (Group Song); 5 p.m. Spoorthi (Vocal) and 6.30 p.m. Hemmige Sri S.Prashanth (Vocal)

October 19; 5 p.m. Malladi Sivanand Yasasvi (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Iyer Sisters (Vocal)

October 20; 5 p.m. Sinshu Rageswari (Vocal); 6.30 p.m. Easwaran Bhattathiri (Vocal)

The programmes are open to all.



10th edition of art festival at Babaji Vidhyashram

Babaji Vidhyashram School has successfully hosted the 10th consecutive edition of its CANVAS Art Festival at its Sholinganallur campus. Marking a decade of celebrating young creative minds, the event has firmly established itself as a one-of-a-kind art extravaganza unique to any school across the state, says a press release. The festival turned the school into a vibrant kaleidoscope of colors.





